MIŻIEN Claim Check 127 · Land and agriculture

Malta’s organic farming: lowest in the EU?

Testing the Commission’s statement on Malta’s share of organic farmland

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Malta has the lowest proportion of organic farming in the EU.”

European Commission, SWD(2026) 702 final, Malta, 2 October 2026.
“Only 66 hectares (less than 1%) … was managed organically in 2022, well below the EU average.”

VERDICT: SUPPORTED

Reproduces from Eurostat in every year tested

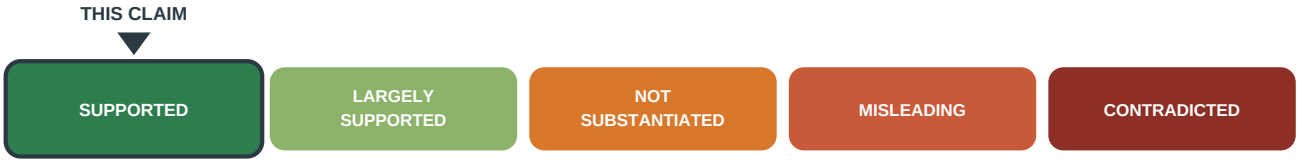
Version 1.0 · 21 October 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from published statistics.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT
Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

The European Commission's assessment of Malta's third river basin management plan, dated 2 October 2026, says: **"Malta has the lowest proportion of organic farming in the EU."** Later it adds that "only 66 hectares (less than 1%)" of Malta's 10 700 hectares of agricultural area "was managed organically in 2022, well below the EU average". We tested the ranking, the 66 hectares and the comparison with the EU average against Eurostat's organic-farming statistics.

1. **The ranking holds in every year we could test.** In Eurostat's series (share of farmland under organic farming) Malta is the lowest reporting Member State in each year from 2012 to 2024. In 2022 it was 0.62%; the next lowest, Bulgaria and Ireland, were at 2.2%.
2. **The 66 hectares is Eurostat's figure for 2022.** Eurostat gives 66 ha of organic land in Malta in 2022 (65 ha fully converted, 1 ha in conversion), and 80 ha in 2023 and 2024. The Commission's own two numbers give 66 / 10 700 = 0.62%.
3. **"Well below the EU average" holds.** Eurostat's last published EU-27 estimate is 9.1% of farmland (2020); Malta was at 0.62% that year, about one fifteenth.
4. **Two minor caveats.** Austria (from 2021) and Greece (from 2022) are missing from Eurostat's latest release, though both were far above Malta when last published. And the 10 700 ha denominator is not named in the document; farm-structure surveys give 9 800 ha (2020) and 8 880 ha (2023). The share stays below 1% on either.
5. **Verdict: supported (high confidence).** The statements reproduce from Eurostat's published data, by year and by country.



0.62% of Malta's farmland was organic in 2022 (Eurostat)

66 ha organic area in 2022, as the Commission says

2.2% the next lowest Member States in 2022 (Bulgaria, Ireland)

9.1% EU-27 average, 2020 (last published estimate)

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

Supported is the top of the scale: nothing moves the verdict up.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

Eurostat revisions that put another Member State below Malta, or a published organic area for Malta well above 66 ha in 2022 (for example from the national register).

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
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5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is in the European Commission's staff working document SWD(2026) 702 final, "Third River Basin Management Plans, Second Flood Hazard and Risk Maps and Second Flood Risk Management Plans, Member State: Malta", dated Brussels, 2 October 2026 [1]. We read it in full on 18 October 2026 from the copy on the Austrian Parliament's website; we did not find the Commission's own copy. Two passages matter. In the description of the country (PDF p. 5): "Malta has the lowest proportion of organic farming in the EU." In the section on pressures (PDF p. 11): "The total agricultural area of Malta is 10 700 hectares, representing 34% of the total land area. Only 66 hectares (less than 1%) of this agricultural area was managed organically in 2022, well below the EU average." The document does not name the source of these figures in the passage; a footnote on p. 29 repeats the 66 hectares and cites a Publications Office report on CAP strategic plans, which we did not open ◆.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
European Commission, SWD(2026) 702 [1]	Lowest organic share in the EU; 66 ha of 10 700 ha organic in 2022.	Read in full (PDF).	**The claim**
Eurostat, sdg_02_40 [2]	Share of utilised agricultural area under organic farming, by country, 2000–2024.	API, all Member States.	Independent
Eurostat, org_cropar [3]	Organic area in hectares by production method (fully converted, in conversion).	API, all Member States.	Independent
Eurostat, ef_lus_main; demo_r_d3area [4]	Utilised agricultural area from farm-structure surveys; land area (316 km²).	API.	Independent

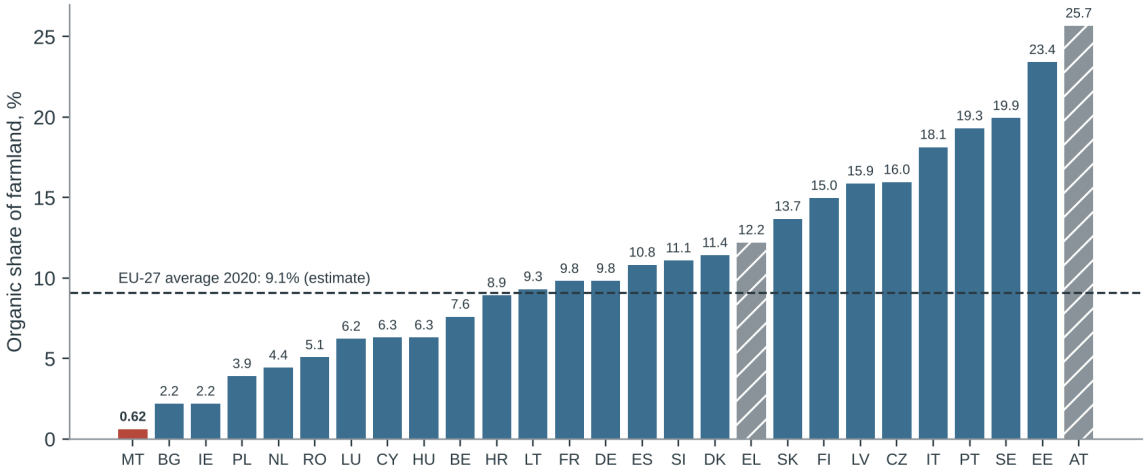
2 Method

Question. Is Malta the lowest in the EU in organic share of farmland, is the 66 hectares right, and is this well below the EU average?

Evidence. We downloaded the Eurostat series through its API on 21 October 2026, saved filtered copies in *data/cc-127/* and ran *tools/cc-127-report/calc.py*. It ranks Malta against every Member State for each year from 2012 to 2024, compares Malta's organic area with the Commission's 66 ha, recomputes 66 / 10 700, and tests the 10 700 ha and 34% against survey and land-area data.

Grades. Eurostat statistics from national reporting: C. Commission document: C. **Verdicts** follow the scale in Appendix A.

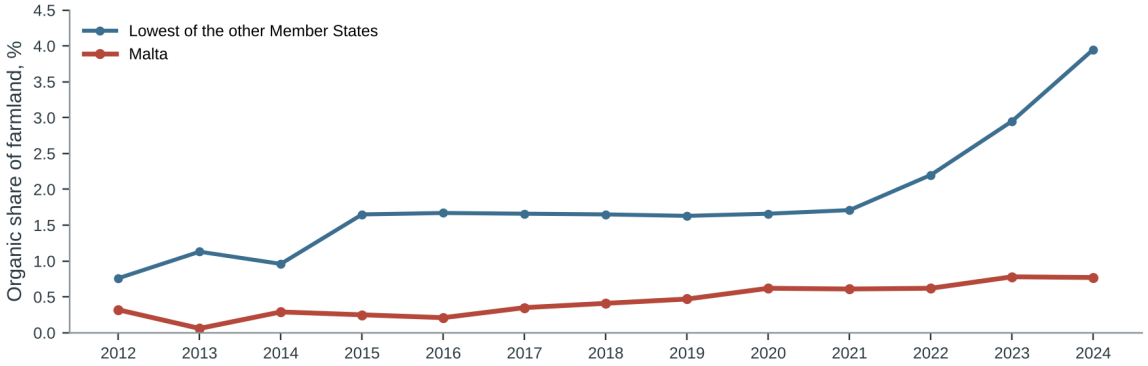
3 What the data show



Eurostat sdg_02_40, 2022; hatched = Austria (2020) and Greece (2021), absent from the 2022 release. Retrieved 21 Oct 2026.

Figure 1. Organic share of farmland by Member State, 2022 (Eurostat). Austria and Greece are missing from the 2022 release; their last published values are hatched.

Malta is at 0.62% in 2022, the lowest of the 25 Member States that report. Austria (25.7% in 2020) and Greece (12.2% in 2021) are absent from the 2022 release, but their last values are far above Malta's. The same holds in 2023 and 2024 (0.78% and 0.77%), with Bulgaria the next lowest (2.95% and 3.95%). In absolute terms Malta's 66 ha compares with 7 749 ha in Cyprus and 8 255 ha in Luxembourg, the next smallest areas.



Eurostat sdg_02_40. From 2021 Austria, and from 2022 Greece, are missing from the release (both were far above Malta when last published).

Figure 2. Malta against the lowest of the other Member States, 2012–2024 (Eurostat).

The gap is persistent: in every year from 2012 to 2024 Malta is below every other reporting Member State. Malta's share has risen from 0.21% in 2016 to 0.77% in 2024, but the next lowest has risen faster since 2021. Eurostat's 2022 hectares are 65 fully converted plus 1 in conversion: the Commission's 66 ha is the total.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

What is the denominator: 10 700 ha, or less? NO MATERIAL CONFLICT

CONSISTENT
Eurostat's share (0.62%) with 66 ha implies about 10 645 ha of farmland, close to the Commission's 10 700 ha. 10 700 ha is 33.9% of Malta's 316 km², as the Commission says.

CAVEAT
Farm-structure surveys give lower utilised agricultural area: 9 800 ha in 2020 and 8 880 ha in 2023. On these, organic land would be 0.68% (66–67 ha in 2020) and 0.90% (80 ha in 2023).

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE
The denominator differs between sources, but the organic share is below 1% on every one tested. The ranking does not depend on it: the next lowest Member State is at 2.2% or more in 2022.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta has the lowest proportion of organic farming in the EU	European Commission [1]	Lowest of all reporting Member States in each year 2012–2024; 0.62% in 2022 against 2.2% for the next [2].	CONFIRMED
B. Only 66 hectares (less than 1%) were organic in 2022	European Commission [1]	Eurostat: 66 ha (65 + 1 in conversion), 0.62% of farmland [2][3].	CONFIRMED
C. That is well below the EU average	European Commission [1]	EU-27 estimate 9.1% in 2020, the last published; Malta 0.62% that year [2]. No EU aggregate for 2022 was found.	CONFIRMED
D. Agricultural area is 10 700 ha, 34% of the land area	European Commission [1]	10 700 / 31 600 ha = 33.9%. Eurostat's implied area is 10 645 ha; surveys give 8 880–9 800 ha [4].	CONSISTENT

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT
SUPPORTED
Every statement reproduces from Eurostat's published data. Confidence: high.

Why. Malta is lowest in each year tested, the 66 hectares is Eurostat's own figure, and the share is far below the last published EU average. **Caveats that do not change the substance.** The 10 700 ha denominator is not sourced in the document and surveys give a smaller area; Austria and Greece are missing from the latest release; and the EU average we cite is for 2020, not 2022. **What this verdict does not say.** It does not say anything about the quality of Malta's farming or about the causes of the low share, and it does not test the document's statements on water.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the Commission: the source and year of the 10 700 ha and the EU average in the passage.
- ☐ From Malta's Agriculture Directorate: the organic register area for 2022–2025, to compare with Eurostat's 66–80 ha.

RIGHT OF REPLY
Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026).

7 Limitations

- We read the Commission document in the Austrian Parliament's copy; the Commission's own copy was not located.
- Eurostat's organic-share series has no EU-27 aggregate after 2020 in the release we used, and lacks Austria from 2021 and Greece from 2022. We compared against those countries' last published values.
- The Commission's 10 700 ha and 34% are not traced to a named source; we only tested them for consistency.
- We did not read the Publications Office report cited in the footnote on p. 29 ◆, and did not check Malta's national organic register.
- The wider document, including its statements on water quality and flood risk, is not tested here.

References

[1] European Commission (2 October 2026). Commission Staff Working Document: Third River Basin Management Plans, Second Flood Hazard and Risk Maps and Second Flood Risk Management Plans, Member State: Malta. SWD(2026) 702 final (copy on the Austrian Parliament website). https://www.parlament.gv.at/dokument/XXVIII/EU/94981/imfname_11680004.pdf

[2] Eurostat. Area under organic farming (share of utilised agricultural area), dataset sdg_02_40. Retrieved 21 October 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/sdg_02_40

[3] Eurostat. Organic crop area by agricultural production methods and crops, dataset org_cropar. Retrieved 21 October 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/org_cropar

[4] Eurostat. Farm structure survey: utilised agricultural area (ef_lus_main); area by NUTS 3 region (demo_r_d3area). Retrieved 21 October 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/ef_lus_main

[5] MiŻien. Data and calculation: data/cc-127/; tools/cc-127-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	21 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Supported (high confidence); no right of reply needed.